
CHELYS SECURITY

LinkedIn Discovery Interview Outreach Guide

Cold Messaging Scripts for Security Practitioners

*This guide contains connection request notes, first-message templates,
follow-up scripts, and a full discovery interview question bank.
Intended for: Marketing team, growth, and founder outreach.*

NOT A SALES SCRIPT - DISCOVERY ONLY

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00 HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Goal: book 20-minute discovery calls with offensive security practitioners. You are NOT selling. You are researching. Every message should feel like it came from a peer, not a vendor.

Security professionals receive vendor pitches daily. They are skeptical, perceptive, and quick to disengage the moment a message feels transactional. The scripts in this guide are designed to bypass that reflex by leading with genuine curiosity and zero ask beyond their time and opinion.

The Two-Step LinkedIn Outreach Flow

1. Send a Connection Request with a short personalized note (300 char limit). Goal: get accepted.
2. Wait 24-48 hours after they accept, then send the First Message. Goal: get a 20-minute call.
3. If no reply in 5-7 days, send one Follow-Up. Then stop - no third message.

Target Personas (Who to Message)

Persona	Description
Penetration Tester	Mid to senior level, consulting or in-house. Runs structured engagements.
Red Team Operator	Internal adversary simulation, advanced TTPs, lateral movement focus.
Bug Bounty Hunter	External assessments, web/API focus, results-driven, tool-heavy workflow.
Offensive Security Eng	Security engineering with offensive skillset, often builds internal tools.
CTF Competitor	Competitive hacker - creative exploitation, deep technical depth.
AppSec / Product Sec	May influence tool purchasing, understands attacker perspective.

NOTE: Do NOT message CISOs or VPs as a first contact. Target individual contributors and senior practitioners. Decision-makers come later, after you have practitioner signal.

Where to Find Them

- * LinkedIn search: title = 'Penetration Tester', 'Red Team', 'Offensive Security', 'Bug Bounty'
- * HackerOne / Bugcrowd leaderboards - top hunters often have LinkedIn profiles linked
- * DEF CON / Black Hat speaker lists - search their names on LinkedIn
- * GitHub profiles of popular offensive security tools - contributors and stars
- * CTFtime.org top teams - look for team members with professional LinkedIn presence
- * SANS, OffSec (OSCP/OSEP), TCM Security community groups on LinkedIn

01 CONNECTION REQUEST NOTES

LinkedIn connection requests allow a 300-character note. Keep it human, specific, and low-pressure. The only goal here is acceptance. Personalize at least one element (their job title, a post they made, a company they work at).

300 character hard limit. Do not go over. Short wins.

Variant A - Straightforward

USE WHEN: YOU HAVE NO SPECIFIC HOOK - GENERIC BUT HONEST

Hey [Name] - I'm building a tool in the offensive security space and trying to talk to real practitioners before I build the wrong thing. Would love to connect and ask you a few questions about your workflow. No pitch, just research.

213 / 300 characters

Variant B - Lead with Their Work

USE WHEN: THEY POSTED SOMETHING, GAVE A TALK, WROTE A WRITEUP, OR SPOKE AT A CON

Hey [Name] - saw your post on [topic / CTF writeup / conference talk]. Really good perspective. I'm doing discovery research on pentesting tooling and would love to get your take. Would you be open to connecting?

218 / 300 characters

Variant C - Peer Framing

USE WHEN: YOU WANT TO SIGNAL YOU'RE A PRACTITIONER YOURSELF, NOT A PURE BUSINESS PERSON

Hey [Name] - I'm a practitioner-turned-builder working on offensive security tooling. Before I get too far into development, I want to talk to people who actually do this work. Mind if I connect?

195 / 300 characters

Variant D - Ultra Short

USE WHEN: YOU WANT MAXIMUM BREVITY - WORKS WELL FOR VERY SENIOR PEOPLE

Hey [Name] - building a pentesting tool, trying to learn from people who do this for real before I build the wrong thing. Would love to connect.

149 / 300 characters

Personalization Tokens

Replace these placeholders before sending. Never send an unedited template.

[Name]	Their first name - always use it
[topic]	A specific post, article, or talk they published
[CTF / competition]	A CTF they competed in or a writeup they published
[conference talk]	DEF CON / Black Hat / BSides talk title
[company]	Their employer if it's a recognizable security firm

02 FIRST MESSAGE TEMPLATES

Send 24-48 hours after they accept your connection. Do not message immediately - it signals automation. Up to 1,900 characters. Lead with context, be specific about what you're asking for, and make it easy to say yes.

The frame that works: 'I'm not pitching you anything. I want your opinion. You'd be doing me a favor.' Make them feel like the expert, because they are.

Template 1 - Generic Pentester / Red Teamer

USE FOR: MID-TO-SENIOR PENTESTERS, RED TEAM OPERATORS, GENERAL OFFENSIVE SEC PRACTITIONERS

Hey [Name], thanks for connecting.

Quick context on why I reached out: I'm working on a new automated penetration testing platform and we're in the early stages of making sure we're building something that actually solves real problems for practitioners - not just something that sounds good in a vendor deck.

I'm not looking to pitch you anything. What I'm after is a 20-minute conversation where I ask you questions: what your current workflow looks like, where existing tools fall short, what would need to be true for you to actually trust an automated tool with parts of an engagement.

Your background in [red teaming / pentesting / offensive security] is exactly the kind of perspective I need. You'd be doing me a genuine favor.

Would you be open to a short discovery call? I'm flexible on timing and happy to work around your schedule.

Template 2 - Bug Bounty Hunter

USE FOR: HACKERONE/BUGCROWD HUNTERS, EXTERNAL WEB/API RESEARCHERS, SOLO OPERATORS

Hey [Name], thanks for connecting.

I'll be straight with you: I'm building a tool aimed at the offensive security space - specifically for folks who do bug bounty and external assessments - and I'm at the stage where I need to talk to people who are actually hunting before I make assumptions about what they need.

This is not a sales conversation. There's nothing to buy. I'm running discovery interviews with practitioners to understand: how you currently scope and prioritize targets, where automation helps vs. gets in the way, and what a tool would need to do to actually be worth adding to your workflow.

20 minutes, no slides, just questions. Your answers will directly shape what we build.

Are you open to it?

Template 3 - Senior / Lead / Security Manager

USE FOR: RED TEAM LEADS, SECURITY ENGINEERING MANAGERS, SENIOR PRACTITIONERS WITH TEAM OVERSIGHT

Hey [Name], thanks for connecting.

I'm in the early development phase of an autonomous penetration testing platform and I'm trying to understand the problem from both sides - the practitioner who runs the engagements and the person who defines what good looks like.

From your background, you've likely seen both. I'd love to get 20 minutes of your time for a discovery interview - not a demo, not a pitch. Just structured questions: what gaps you see in the current tooling landscape, what your team actually needs vs. what vendors promise, and where you think automation realistically fits into offensive security workflows.

Completely off the record if you prefer. I'm just trying to build the right thing.

Would that be something you'd be open to?

Template 4 - CTF Competitor / Technical Researcher

USE FOR: COMPETITIVE HACKERS, CVE RESEARCHERS, EXPLOIT DEVELOPERS, CONFERENCE SPEAKERS

Hey [Name], thanks for connecting.

I came across your work on [CTF / competition / writeup / conference talk] and wanted to reach out directly.

I'm developing a penetration testing tool and I'm specifically looking to talk to people who think about exploitation creatively - not just people who run canned playbooks. Someone with your background would give me a perspective most vendor research completely misses.

I'm not selling anything. What I'm doing is a series of short discovery interviews to understand what tools practitioners actually rely on, where existing platforms fail to model real attack behavior, and what would need to be true for an automated tool to be genuinely useful to someone like you.

20 minutes. I'll come with questions, you give me honest answers. That's it.

Up for it?

Template 5 - Short Version (High-Volume Outreach)

USE FOR: WHEN RUNNING HIGHER VOLUME - SHORTER, STILL PERSONAL, QUICK TO READ

Hey [Name], thanks for connecting.

I'm running discovery interviews for a pentesting tool we're building - specifically trying to understand what practitioners actually need, not what vendors assume they need.

No pitch, no demo. Just 20 minutes of your time and your honest opinion on where current tooling falls short.

Would you be open to a quick call?

03 FOLLOW-UP MESSAGE

Send this if you receive no reply 5-7 days after the first message. Send it once. If they do not reply to the follow-up, do not message again - move on. Persistence past two messages damages your brand with this audience.

NOTE: Security professionals are often busy, sometimes paranoid about unsolicited outreach, and rarely check LinkedIn daily. One follow-up is fine and expected. Two is harassment.

Follow-Up Template

SEND: 5-7 DAYS AFTER FIRST MESSAGE IF NO REPLY

Hey [Name] - just following up in case this got buried.

Still running discovery interviews for a pentesting tool we're building. Looking for 20 minutes with practitioners who are willing to share where existing tools fall short. No pitch involved.

If timing is bad right now, totally understand - feel free to ignore this. But if you have any interest in shaping what gets built, I'd love to chat.

387 / 1900 characters

If They Decline or Say They're Busy

OPTIONAL RESPONSE - KEEP THE DOOR OPEN WITHOUT BEING PUSHY

Totally understood, no worries at all. If you ever have 20 minutes down the road and want to share your perspective, I'd genuinely welcome it. Thanks for responding either way - appreciate it.

If They Ask 'What's the Tool?'

Answer honestly but briefly. Do not go into a full pitch. Return to asking questions.

It's an autonomous penetration testing platform - it runs a coordinated agent swarm to discover and validate real attack paths across infrastructure. Still in active development, which is exactly why I'm talking to practitioners before we harden the roadmap. Happy to share more after we chat - but first I'd really rather just hear about your experience with current tooling. What does your stack look like today?

NOTE: Pivot immediately back to a question. The goal of every exchange is to get them talking, not to have them evaluate your product.

04 DISCOVERY INTERVIEW QUESTION BANK

Use this once they agree to a call. Run it as a conversation, not a survey. The questions below are a guide - follow the thread if they go somewhere interesting. Your job is to listen more than you speak.

Opening Frame - Say This Word for Word at the Start

Before we start - I want to be clear about what this is. I'm not going to pitch you anything today. I'm going to ask you questions, take notes, and mostly listen. The goal is to understand your actual workflow and where things break down. There are no wrong answers and nothing you say will be used to sell you anything.

Section A - Current Workflow

GOAL: UNDERSTAND THEIR ACTUAL DAY-TO-DAY BEFORE YOU ASK ABOUT TOOLING

1. Walk me through how a typical engagement starts for you - from scoping to first recon. What does that look like?
2. How much of what you do is structured / repeatable vs. improvised in the moment?
3. Where do you spend time on things that feel like they should be automatable but aren't?
4. What does your reporting process look like at the end of an engagement? How long does it take?

Section B - Current Tooling

GOAL: UNDERSTAND WHAT THEY TRUST, WHAT THEY HATE, AND WHY

1. Which tools are non-negotiable in your kit? What would you never replace, and why?
2. Have you tried any automated pentesting platforms - Pentera, NodeZero, anything similar? What did they get right? What did they get wrong?
3. When a tool gives you a finding - what makes you trust it enough to put it in a report?
4. What's the most frustrating thing about the tools you use today?

Section C - Attitudes Toward Automation

GOAL: UNDERSTAND THEIR MENTAL MODEL OF WHERE AI/AUTOMATION FITS - OR DOESN'T

1. When you think about automation in offensive security - where does it genuinely help?
2. Where does automation get in the way, create noise, or give you false confidence?
3. If a tool handed you a confirmed, multi-hop attack path with evidence - what would need to be true for you to trust it?
4. What's the difference between a tool that assists you and one that replaces a decision you should be making yourself?

Section D - Wish List

GOAL: UNCOVER UNMET NEEDS IN THEIR OWN WORDS

1. What's the one thing you wish existed in offensive security tooling that doesn't?
2. If you could hand a junior team member a tool and have them produce the same quality of recon you do - what would that tool need to do?
3. What would make you immediately recommend a new tool to a colleague?
4. What would make you immediately distrust it?

Closing - Always End With This

This has been really helpful - genuinely. I have one last question: is there anyone else you think I should be talking to? Other practitioners, red team leads, someone who's tried a lot of tools and has strong opinions? I'm trying to build a diverse picture and a warm intro always goes a long way.

NOTE: Referrals from respected practitioners are the highest-quality leads you can get. Always ask. Even one name per interview compounds quickly.

05 TONE RULES AND COMMON MISTAKES

What Works With This Audience

- * Direct and honest - 'I'm building X and I need your opinion' beats any clever hook
- * Peer framing - position yourself as a fellow practitioner, not a vendor
- * Specific asks - '20 minutes' is more trustworthy than 'a quick chat'
- * Low pressure - make it easy to say no; paradoxically, it makes them more likely to say yes
- * Technical credibility - drop one specific, accurate technical detail to signal you know the domain

What Kills Response Rates Instantly

- * Vendor language: 'AI-powered', 'next-gen', 'revolutionary', 'game-changing' - immediate delete
- * Vague asks: 'I'd love to connect and learn more' - too soft, no clear next step
- * Pitching in the first message - ruins trust before the conversation starts
- * Mentioning pricing, trials, or demos before they've asked
- * Wall of text - security professionals are busy; long first messages get ignored
- * Generic messages with obvious placeholders left unfilled - destroys credibility
- * Following up more than once - comes across as desperate or automated

Messaging Do's and Don'ts

DO	DON'T
+ Use their first name in every message	- Start with 'Hi there' or 'Dear Sir/Madam'
+ Reference something specific about their work	- Send the same message to 50 people identically
+ State clearly it's not a sales pitch	- Say 'discovery call' and mean 'demo'
+ Ask for exactly 20 minutes	- Ask for 'a few minutes' or 'some time'
+ Let them pick the format (Zoom, phone, async)	- Insist on a specific platform
+ Send one follow-up if no reply	- Send 3+ messages or connect on other platforms
+ Thank them regardless of their answer	- Argue or try to convince if they decline
+ Ask for referrals at the end of every call	- Only ask for referrals from people you liked

Handling Skeptical Responses

IF THEY SAY: 'IS THIS A SALES PITCH?'

No, genuinely not. There's nothing to buy right now. I'm at the stage where I'm trying to understand the problem before I build the solution. The only thing I'm asking for is 20 minutes and your honest opinion.

IF THEY SAY: 'I DON'T HAVE TIME'

Totally fair - I appreciate you responding. If anything changes or you find a gap in your schedule, I'd still love to hear from you. And if you know someone who might be willing to share their perspective, I'd welcome an intro.

IF THEY SAY: 'SEND ME MORE INFO FIRST'

Happy to. The short version: I'm building an autonomous penetration testing platform and I'm in the discovery phase, trying to make sure we're solving real problems rather than assumed ones. I'd rather hear your questions in context than send a one-pager that misses what matters to you - but if you prefer something written first, I can put together a few short bullet points. What would be most useful?

06 OUTREACH TRACKING AND GOALS

Target Metrics (Per Month)

Metric	Target	Notes
Connection requests sent	60 - 100	Aim for 3-5 per day, avoid weekends
Connection acceptance rate	30 - 45%	20-45 accepted connections per month
First message reply rate	15 - 25%	3-11 replies from accepted connections
Discovery calls booked	5 - 10	1 call per 10-15 connections as baseline
Referrals per call	0.5 - 1.0	Ask every time; 50% will give a name

What to Log After Every Call

- * Their current tool stack (what they use and trust)
- * Their biggest pain point in one sentence
- * Their attitude toward automation: skeptic / open / advocate
- * Any specific feature they said they wished existed
- * Referrals given (name + LinkedIn + context)
- * Would they be willing to beta test? (yes / maybe / no)
- * Overall signal: strong ICP match / weak match / different segment

Turning Interviews Into Product Signal

After every 5 calls, look for patterns across your notes:

- * Which pain points came up 3+ times? These are validated problems worth building for.
- * Which tools keep appearing? Understand why they're trusted before competing with them.
- * Which features got the strongest reaction? Quote their exact words in internal planning docs.
- * Who were the most enthusiastic? These are your early adopter candidates for beta.

5-10 quality interviews will tell you more about your market than any survey or analyst report. A practitioner's honest 20 minutes is worth more than 500 anonymous form responses.

The single most important rule:

You are not selling. You are learning.

Every message, every call, every follow-up should feel like it comes from someone who genuinely wants to understand the problem - because it should. The moment it feels like a sales motion, you lose the practitioner.

Security professionals talk to each other. A good conversation leads to referrals. A bad one - or one that felt like a pitch - gets mentioned in Slack channels and Discord servers. Reputation in this community compounds in both directions.

Do this right: listen more than you talk, ask better questions than they expect, and always leave them feeling like they got something out of the conversation too.

Listen. Learn. Build the right thing.